
“I have never **advocated war**
except as a **means of**
peace.”

ULYSSES S. GRANT, FROM HIS *PERSONAL MEMOIRS*, 1886

Ulysses S. Grant was the top commander of the Union Army for much of the Civil War, leading it to victory in the most bitter conflict in American history. After the war, in 1868, he became the 18th president of the United States, but his administration was blighted by reports of corruption, scandal, and impropriety.

Humble beginnings

Born Hiram Ulysses Grant on April 27, 1822, in a two-room log cabin in Point Pleasant, Ohio, the future general grew up working on his father's farm—though even as a young man he had ambitions for greater things. He attended West Point, where his name was mistakenly recorded as Ulysses Simpson Grant, and he kept the erroneous middle initial for life. At West Point he excelled in horsemanship but was not the best scholar, nor was he considered an exceptional military mind. He eventually graduated 21st out of a class of 39. Grant's early military experiences echoed his relationship with his former instructors: He did not take orders well and he often clashed with his superiors. He also had a tendency to drink to excess when feeling “blue and depressed.”

An “unjust” war

While serving in the War with Mexico (1846–48), Grant was outspoken in his criticism of the conflict. Feeling it to be unjust, he stated publicly that he was “bitterly opposed” to it. Yet he showed great bravery and cunning when, during the Battle of Chapultepec, he climbed to the top of a church bell tower with a howitzer and